

IS HOMEWORK NECESSARY?

Education, Equity and the Debate That Has Lasted Over a Century • LEVEL B



Schools across the United States and beyond are re-examining the role of homework in students' lives.

Schools are getting rid of homework from Essex, Massachusetts, to Los Angeles, California. Although the no-homework trend may sound **alarming**, especially to parents dreaming of their child's acceptance to top universities, there is **mounting** evidence that **eliminating** homework in primary school may actually bring significant benefits — particularly when it comes to **educational equity**. In fact, while the push to eliminate homework may surprise many adults, the debate is not new. Parents and educators have been discussing this subject for over a century, and the educational **pendulum** continues to swing **back and forth** between the need for homework and the need to remove it entirely.

- The Problem: It Highlights Inequalities
- How Much Is Too Much?
- When Does It Actually Help?
- Negative Effects on Students
- How Teachers Can Help

The Problem with Homework: It Highlights Inequalities

One of the most pressing concerns about homework is how it **disproportionately** affects students from less **affluent** families. The American Psychological Association (APA) has pointed out that children from wealthier homes are more likely to have access to computers, internet connections, quiet study areas, and parents who are educated and available to help with difficult assignments. In contrast, students from **disadvantaged homes** are more likely to work at after-school jobs, or to be at home without adult supervision while their parents work multiple jobs.

"Kids from wealthier homes are more likely to have resources such as computers, internet connections, dedicated areas to do schoolwork and parents who tend to be more educated and more available to help them with tricky assignments."

— American Psychological Association (APA)

While students in more **affluent** areas are often playing sports, taking part in **recreational activities** after school, or receiving private tutoring, children in disadvantaged areas are more likely to be working, caring for siblings, or dealing with an unstable home environment. Adding homework to this situation creates an additional **burden** — and for students who are already struggling, the task of completing it at the end of a long school day can feel overwhelming. While all students may **groan** at the mention of homework, for those facing economic hardship it can become far more than just a **nuisance**.

Beyond the **logistical** issues, homework can also have a negative impact on physical health and **stress** levels. A study covering more than 4,300 students from high-performing schools in upper-middle-class communities found that **excessive** homework was associated with high stress levels, physical health problems, and a lack of balance in students' lives. In fact, 56% of students in the study named homework as their primary source of stress. This raises an important question: if even students from more privileged backgrounds are suffering, what does this mean for the wider **consensus** on homework policy?

56%

of students name homework as their #1
source of stress

6.8 hrs

average homework per week for high school
students

4 hrs

weekly threshold after which homework
shows little benefit

How Much Homework Is Too Much Homework?

The National Education Association and the National Parent Teacher Association recommend that students spend 10 minutes per grade level per night on homework — meaning first graders should do 10 minutes, second graders 20 minutes, and so on. However, research published by The American Journal of Family Therapy found that students are regularly assigned far more than this. By sixth grade, this guideline already adds up to one hour per night, yet the National Center for Education Statistics reports that high school students average 6.8 hours of homework per week. Importantly, this figure does not **take into consideration** the additional challenges faced by **underprivileged** student populations.

Research conducted by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) found that after around four hours of homework per week, any additional time invested has **a negligible impact** on **academic performance**. In other words, asking students to spend an hour or more per day on homework may not only fail to help them — according to the **aforementioned** studies, it may actually be harming them, both physically and emotionally.

It is also worth noting that homework is expected to be completed after a full school day that typically lasts six to seven hours. Research into how people develop **expertise** suggests that even highly skilled professionals — such as musicians, scientists, and athletes — perform their most productive work for only around four hours per day. This raises an important question about whether it is realistic, or even beneficial, to expect students to continue learning effectively for hours beyond the school day.

When Does Homework Actually Help?

In the context of modern education, homework is a relatively recent idea in the United States. It was educational reformer Horace Mann who first introduced the concept to America, inspired by schools in Prussia. Since then, its popularity has ebbed and flowed. In the 1930s, homework was considered a form of child labour. Then, in the 1950s, implementing mandatory homework was hailed as a way to ensure American students stayed ahead during the Cold War. It was formally required by the U.S. Department of Education in 1986 and has remained widespread ever since.

That said, schoolwork completed outside school hours is not without its benefits. Numerous studies have shown that well-designed homework can help improve student performance and strengthen the connection between students and their learning. The key is balance — and recognising that not all homework is equally valuable for all students.

■ BENEFITS OF HOMEWORK

- Completion of take-home assignments has been linked to improved standardized test results.
- Students who regularly complete homework are more likely to attend college.
- Homework helps students retain more of what they learn in class.
- It develops good academic habits: time management, organisation, and problem-solving.
- It allows parents to stay involved in their children's learning and identify any difficulties.

■ DRAWBACKS OF HOMEWORK

- Excessive homework is associated with stress, sleep deprivation, and health problems.
- It disproportionately disadvantages students from lower socioeconomic backgrounds.
- Pressure to complete homework can tempt students into plagiarizing or cheating.
- It highlights digital equity gaps — many students lack internet access at home.
- Research shows homework has little benefit for younger students at primary level.

Negative Effects of Homework for Students

While some homework may help students connect to their learning and improve their classroom performance, too much can have serious negative effects. Students regularly report that homework is their primary source of stress. Higher-achieving students — those who often receive more homework — are particularly at risk for stress-related health issues, including sleep deprivation, weight loss, and headaches. Furthermore, excessive homework takes time away from the extracurricular activities, hobbies, and social interactions that are essential for healthy development.

There is also the question of academic honesty. Under pressure to hand in assignments, many students resort to copying others' work or plagiarizing online sources. In some cases, parents may even complete assignments on behalf of their children. Additionally, as homework increasingly requires a computer and internet connection, students without access to these at home — who are disproportionately from low-income families — are placed at a significant disadvantage. This issue of digital equity became especially visible during the COVID-19 pandemic, when all schoolwork moved online and those without internet access fell behind academically.

How Teachers Can Help

Teachers play a vital role in making homework a more equitable and effective experience. Rather than assigning large quantities of homework, educators can focus on quality — setting tasks that genuinely reinforce classroom learning and are achievable for all students, regardless of their home circumstances. It is also important to

consider whether the assignment requires resources that some students may not have access to, and to provide alternatives where necessary. Being mindful of the **socioeconomic** diversity within a class is the first step towards making homework fairer for everyone.

ACTIVITIES

1 Read the article and decide if these statements are True (T), False (F), or Not Given (NG).

- 1 The debate about homework has only started in recent years.
- 2 The APA found that wealthier students have more access to study resources.
- 3 56% of students from disadvantaged backgrounds named homework as their main stressor.
- 4 The OECD found that more than four hours of homework per week has little extra benefit.
- 5 Horace Mann introduced homework to America from Prussia.
- 6 All teachers agree that homework should be abolished.

2 Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to their meanings.

- 1 done in a way that affects some groups more than others
- 2 having more than enough money and a comfortable lifestyle
- 3 the general agreement of opinion among a group of experts
- 4 having little to no effect; too small to matter
- 5 something that was previously mentioned
- 6 activities done outside of regular school lessons

3 Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 Why does homework create more of a burden for students from disadvantaged backgrounds?
- 2 According to the OECD, at what point does homework stop being effective?
- 3 What were the findings of the study on high-performing California school students?
- 4 How did the COVID-19 pandemic reveal the problem of digital equity?
- 5 What does the article suggest teachers should focus on when setting homework?

4 Discussion: Consider both sides of the argument. Write a short paragraph (80–100 words) giving your own opinion on whether homework should be reduced or removed.

Use evidence from the article to support your view.

Consider: Who benefits from homework? Who is harmed by it? What would you change?

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think homework is fair for all students? Why / Why not?

Should the amount of homework depend on the subject or the student's age?

Is there a difference between useful homework and homework that just keeps students busy?

What would school look like if homework were completely abolished?